SAMPLE

Abu Lahab: The Uncle Who Rejected

Abu Lahab (أبو لهب) in the Quran

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Introduction

Abu Lahab is the only person condemned by name in the Quran. His real name was Abdul Uzza, but he was known as Abu Lahab -- "Father of Flame" -- for his fiery temperament and his reddish complexion. He was the paternal uncle of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him), the son of Abdul Muttalib, the brother of Abdullah, the uncle who should have been the protector but who became the enemy.

The Quran devotes an entire surah to him -- Surah Al-Masad (111), also called Surah Al-Lahab. Five verses, one person, one verdict: "Perish the hands of Abu Lahab, and perish he! His wealth will not avail him or what he gained. He will burn in a Fire of blazing flame. And his wife too, who carries wood. Around her neck is a rope of twisted fiber" (111:1-5).

This surah is unique in the Quran. It is the only surah that condemns a named individual -- not a nation, not a people, not a title, but a person with a name. Abu Lahab is named. His wife is described. His wealth is mentioned. His fate is decreed. The surah is the personal verdict -- the verdict that was revealed while Abu Lahab was alive, the verdict that he could read as his own condemnation, the verdict that he could not change despite his wealth and his power.

Abu Lahab's story is the story of the proximity that became the enmity. He was not a stranger to the Prophet -- he was the uncle, the family, the blood. He grew up in the same household, shared the same father, lived in the same city. But when the Prophet received the revelation, Abu Lahab chose to oppose. He chose to mock, to persecute, to attack. He chose the enmity over the faith, the fire over the truth, the wealth over the message.

This book -- the second in The Warned Ones series -- covers Abu Lahab: the surah that condemns him, his relation to the Prophet, his opposition and hostility, his wealth and its uselessness, his wife and her punishment, the fire that is his destiny, the meaning of his name, his connections to the other warned figures, and the lessons for every person who has the proximity to the truth but who chooses the opposition.

Abu Lahab is the warning that the proximity is not the faith -- and the faith that is not chosen is the faith that is not held, and the proximity that is not the faith is the proximity that becomes the enmity. He is the uncle who rejected, the family who opposed, the blood who became the enemy. His story is the cautionary tale of the person who had every reason to believe and every opportunity to accept, but who chose the fire instead.

Chapter 1: The Surah -- 111:1-5

Surah Al-Masad (111) -- also called Surah Al-Lahab -- is five verses:

"Perish the hands of Abu Lahab, and perish he! His wealth will not avail him or what he gained. He will burn in a Fire of blazing flame. And his wife too, who carries wood. Around her neck is a rope of twisted fiber" (111:1-5).

The five verses are the significance: the surah that is five verses is the surah that is the complete verdict -- the condemnation, the reason, the punishment, the accomplice, and the instrument. The five verses are the lesson: the person who reads the surah reads the complete story of a person -- the person who is named, the person who is condemned, the person whose wealth is useless, the person whose wife is punished, and the person whose fate is the fire.

The surah opens: "Perish the hands of Abu Lahab, and perish he!" (تبت يدا أبي لهب وتب). The condemnation is the significance: the surah that opens with the condemnation is the surah that opens with the verdict -- and the verdict that opens is the verdict that is the decree. The condemnation is the lesson: the person who is condemned is the person who is named -- and the name that is the condemnation is the name that is the personal verdict, and the personal verdict that is the name is the personal verdict that is the justice.

The surah says: "His wealth will not avail him or what he gained" (ما أغنى عنه ماله وما كسب). The wealth is the significance: Abu Lahab was one of the wealthiest men in Makkah -- and the wealth that was the greatest was the wealth that was the most useless. The wealth is the lesson: the person who relies on the wealth should know that the wealth does not avail -- and the wealth that does not avail is the wealth that is the illusion, and the illusion that is the wealth is the illusion that is the lesson of Abu Lahab.

The surah says: "He will burn in a Fire of blazing flame" (سيصلى نارا ذات لهب). The fire is the significance: Abu Lahab -- "Father of Flame" -- will burn in the flame -- and the flame that is the name is the flame that is the destiny. The fire is the lesson: the person whose name is the flame will burn in the flame -- and the name that is the destiny is the name that is the justice, and the justice that is the name is the justice that is the poetic, and the poetic that is the justice is the poetic that is the decree.

The surah says: "And his wife too, who carries wood" (وامرأته حملات الحطب). The wife is the significance: the wife who carried the thorns and the brambles to throw in the path of the Prophet is the wife who carries the wood -- and the wood that is carried is the wood that is the punishment. The wife is the lesson: the person who carries the harm carries the wood -- and the wood that is the harm is the wood that is the punishment, and the punishment that is the wood is the punishment that is the justice.

The surah says: "Around her neck is a rope of twisted fiber" (في جيدها حبل من مسد). The rope is the significance: the wife who carried the thorns has a rope around her neck -- and the rope that is the neck is the rope that is the restraint. The rope is the lesson: the person who carries the harm is restrained by the rope -- and the rope that is the restraint is the rope that is the consequence, and the consequence that is the rope is the consequence that is the justice, and the justice that is the rope is the justice that is the fitting.

The surah of five verses is the complete warning -- the warning that includes the person, the wealth, the fire, the accomplice, and the instrument. The complete warning is the significance: the surah that is complete is the surah that leaves nothing out -- and the nothing that is left out is the nothing that is the complete. The complete warning is the lesson: the person who reads the surah reads the complete warning -- and the warning that is complete is the warning that is the personal, and the personal that is the warning is the personal that is the Abu Lahab, and the Abu Lahab that is the warning is the Abu Lahab that is the lesson for every person who has the proximity and who chooses the opposition.